THE JAPANESE OFFENSIVE

THE SURPRISE ATTACK by Japanese naval aircraft on the American naval base at Pearl Harbor on December 7, 1941, was the first of a series of bold aggressive moves that within six months gave Japan control of all of southeast Asia and much of the Pacific. The navies of Britain and the Netherlands were able to put up little more than token resistance to an enemy overwhelmingly superior both in heavy-gun warships and in land- and carrier-based aviation. It fell to the US Navy to contest the dominance of the Japanese at sea. The Americans faced an opponent not only superior in numbers but also highly motivated, well trained, and in some departments, better equipped. Yet at the decisive battle of Midway in June 1942 the Japanese carrier force that had humiliated the United States at Pearl Harbor was itself crushingly defeated. The fierce battles fought around the island of Guadalcanal during the second half of 1942 showed that the Japanese Imperial Navy was still confident and aggressive, but Japan had ultimately failed to achieve a decisive naval victory while the balance of power at sea was most in its favor.

WORLD WAR II



PEARL HARBOR

Date	December 7, 1941
Location	Pearl Harbor, Oahu, Hawaii
Result	Japanese victory

COMBATANTS

JAPAN	UNITED STATES

COMMANDERS

Isoroku Yamamoto **Chuichi Nagumoe**	**Husband E. Kimmel**

FORCES

Ships: 2 battleships, 6 carriers, 28 submarines, 23 other ships, 432 aircraft (353 on raid)	**Ships:** 90 ships including 8 battleships, 300 aircraft

LOSSES

Men: 55 **Ships:** 1 submarine, 5 midget submarines	**Men:** 2,403 **Ships:** 18 ships sunk or seriously damaged

PEARL HARBOR

On November 26, 1941, a Japanese naval task force commanded by Vice Admiral Chuichi Nagumo slipped out of Hitokapu Bay in the Kurile Islands bound for Hawaii. The force included six aircraft carriers: *Akagi*, *Kaga*, *Zuikaku*, *Shaokaku*, *Hiryu*, and *Soryu*. Its goal was to attack and destroy the US Pacific Fleet in its base at Pearl Harbor. The key figure behind the Pearl Harbor raid was Admiral Isoroku Yamamoto: Japan had decided to seize Malaya and the Dutch East Indies and, convinced this must mean war with the United States, Yamamoto planned a preemptive strike against the US fleet, to coincide with, rather than follow, a declaration of war.

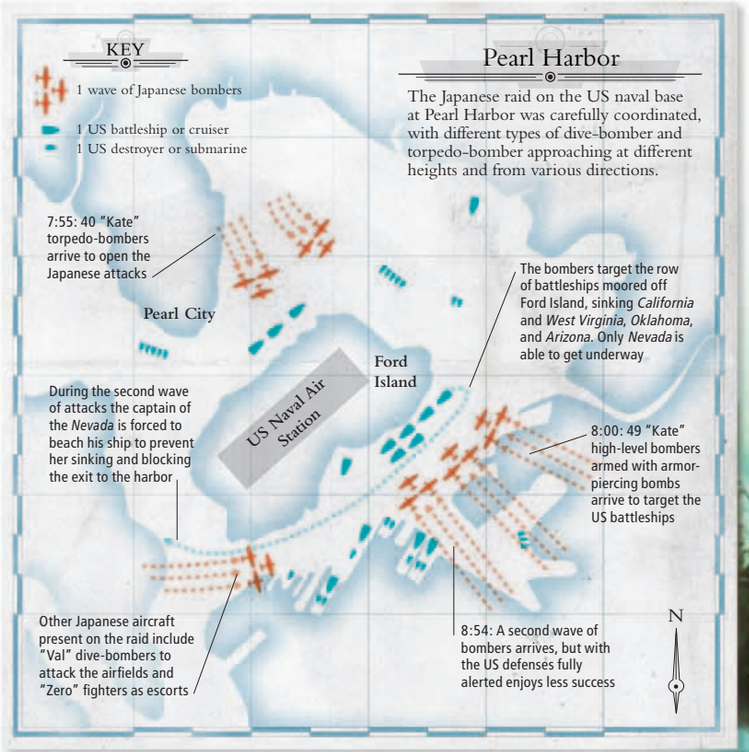
The operation depended on total surprise. Observing strict radio silence, Nagumo's force would cross thousands of miles of ocean undetected, refuelling from tankers en route. A separate force of Japanese submarines also proceeded to Pearl Harbor, full-size boats carrying midget submarines to penetrate the American defenses. At dawn on December 7, 250 miles (400 km) north of Hawaii, the first wave of 183 Japanese aircraft took off from their carriers—Nakajima "Kate" torpedo-bombers, Mitsubishi "Zero" fighters, and Aichi "Val" dive-bombers.



Binoculars from USS *Arizona*
The first ship to be sunk at Pearl Harbor, the battleship *Arizona* was ripped apart by an explosion in its forward magazine.

Although Japan and the US were not at war, diplomatic relations had reached a breaking point and American forces should have been on full alert. But Pearl Harbor was enjoying a sleepy peacetime Sunday morning. The incoming aircraft were picked up on radar and one midget submarine was spotted, but none of this disturbed the Americans. The ship's band was playing on the deck of the battleship *Nevada* as the bombs began to fall. The aircraft that should have defended the base were destroyed as they sat on the ground.

Japan's naval pilots were a highly trained elite flying the world's best carrier aircraft. It is believed that 90 percent of the torpedoes at Pearl Harbor found their target, as did around 60 percent of the bombs dropped by dive-bombers. Within 20 minutes of the start of the attack the battleship *Oklahoma* had capsized after hits by five torpedoes, while *Arizona* had suffered



> "YESTERDAY, DECEMBER 7, 1941—A DATE WHICH WILL LIVE IN INFAMY—THE UNITED STATES OF AMERICA WAS SUDDENLY AND DELIBERATELY ATTACKED."
>
> **PRESIDENT FRANKLIN D. ROOSEVELT**, SPEECH TO CONGRESS ON DECEMBER 8, 1941

